

JUDAISM CANON

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Abstract

Example

Contents

God chose Israel through covenant. The covenant is conditional (blessings and curses) and eternal.

Example: Hear, O Israel: the LORD our God, the LORD is one (Deuteronomy 6:4). The Shema is the declarative foundation monotheism as covenantal claim, not philosophical argument.

2. Torah as Constitution

The Torah (Written + Oral) is the governing document. All Jewish life derives from Torah interpretation.

Example: The Talmud records centuries of rabbinical debate about Torah application. Turn it and turn it, for everything is in it (Pirkei Avot 5:22). The evidence is inexhaustible because interpretation is infinite.

3. Sacred History

Judaism is grounded in remembered events: Exodus, Sinai, Exile, Return. Memory is obligation.

Example: In every generation, one must see oneself as if one personally went out of Egypt (Haggadah). The Seder liturgy collapses temporal distance the past is present.

4. People as Boundary

The relational unit is Am Yisrael (the people of Israel). Membership by birth or conversion (giyur).

Example: Who is a Jew? is the fundamental relational question. Orthodox, Conservative, Reform define the boundary differently the disagreement IS the relational governance in action.

5. Halakhic Practice

Jewish law (halakha) governs daily life: kashrut, Shabbat, prayer, tzedakah, lifecycle.

Example: 613 commandments (mitzvot) in the Torah, expanded through Talmudic interpretation into comprehensive life governance. Observance IS operational compliance.

6. Institutional Persistence

Judaism maintained governance without state or territory for 2000 years through structural innovation.

Example: After Temple destruction (70 CE), the synagogue replaced the Temple, the rabbi replaced the priest, prayer replaced sacrifice. The structure adapted while the governance survived.

Constraints

MUST: Cite Torah, Talmud, or halakhic source for doctrinal claims

MUST: Distinguish Orthodox from Conservative from Reform positions

MUST NOT: Present one movement's halakhic ruling as universal Jewish law

JUDAISM / CANON / RELIGION